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Engagement as Justice



COLLEGE 117
April 6, 2026
PROF. DAPHNE MARTSCHENKO
PROF. NICOLE MARTINEZ

Recap of last week

Rawls

- Veil of Ignorance
- Difference principle

Daniels:

- Health is of special moral importance
- “What do we owe each other to promote and protect health in a population and to assist people when they are ill or disabled?”



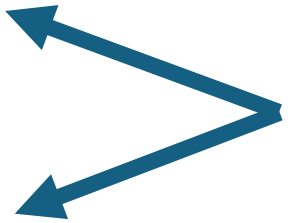
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Frameworks to help **identify, analyze, and assist** in navigation of ethical dilemmas and uncertainties

This week

Understand what "participatory justice" is

Examine how engagement is employed to advance participatory justice

Today's guiding questions

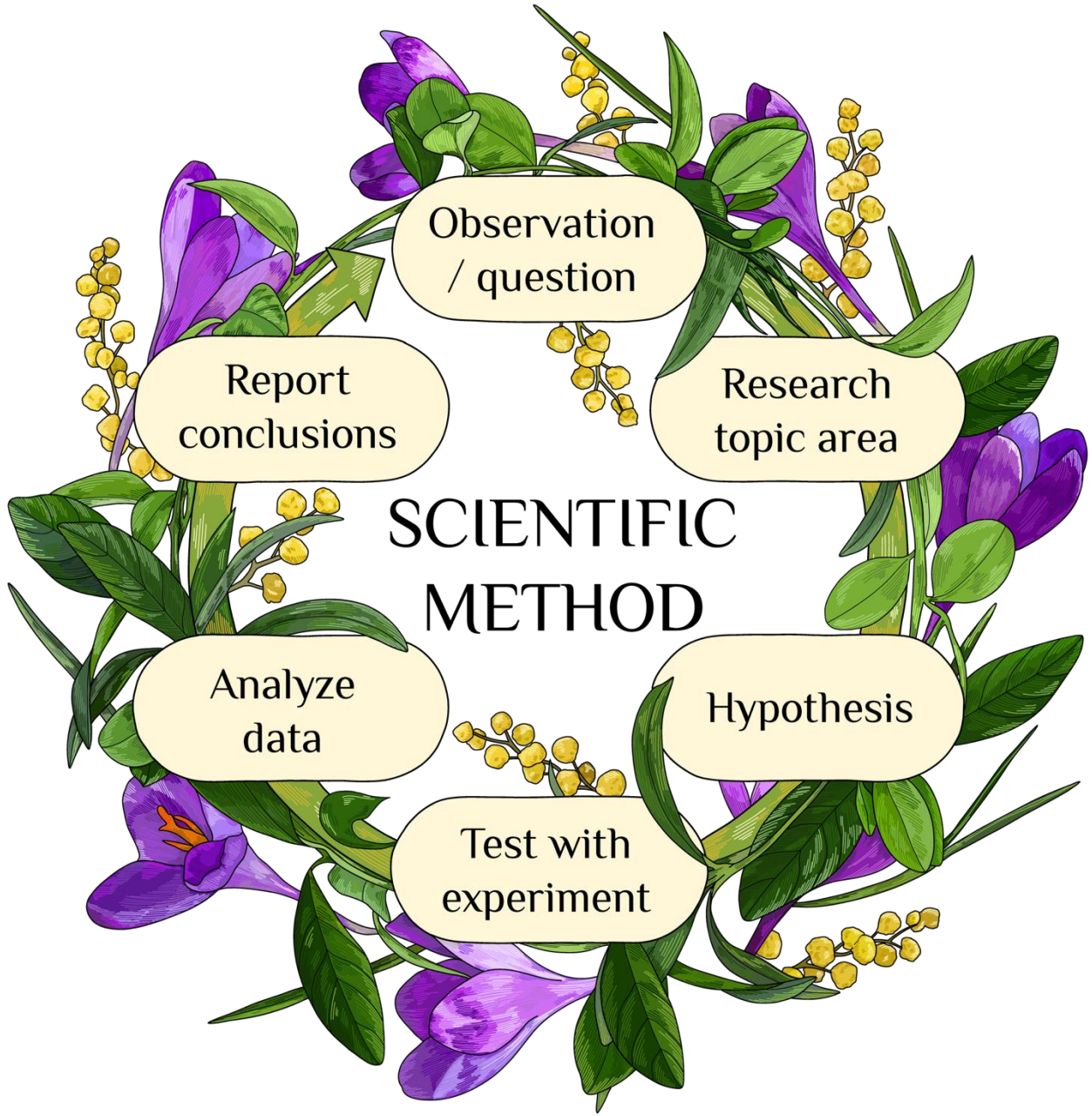


1. Who get to be decision-makers in the production of science & technology?

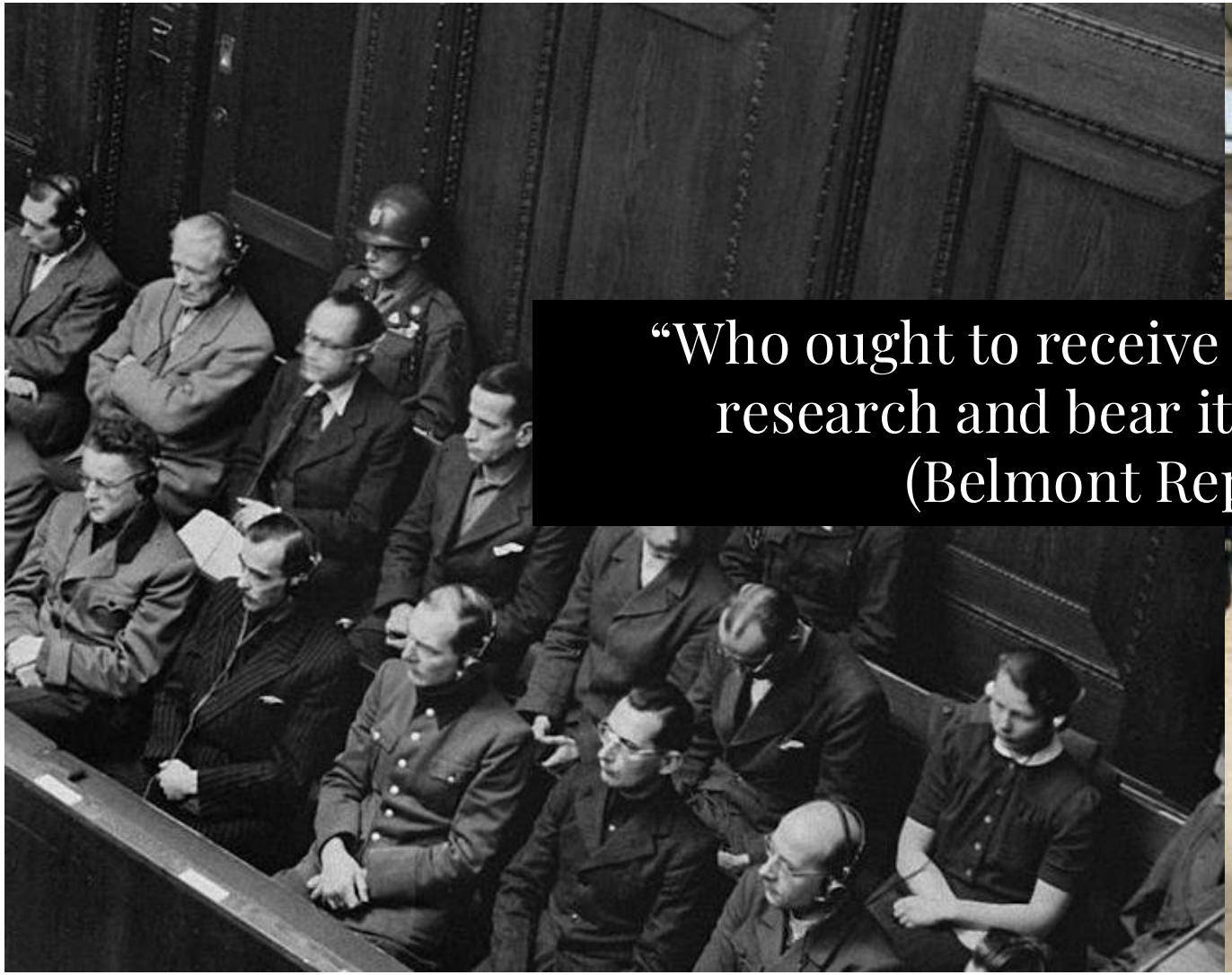
2. What does it mean to secure participatory justice in the production of science & technology?

Research undergirds the development of technologies




Observation / question
Research topic area
Hypothesis
Test with experiment
Analyze data
Report conclusions
SCIENTIFIC METHOD

Many ideas about what is ethical in research emerged in reaction to harmful events





"Who ought to receive the benefits of research and bear its burdens?"
(Belmont Report)

Who gets to decide what is ethical?

Nobody has responded yet.

Hang tight! Responses are coming in.

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Who gets to decide what is ethical?

Funding agencies

Laws & regulations

Institutional Review Board (Ethics Review Boards)

Scientific community

The public (though typically after the fact)

Institutional Review Boards

IRB committee must have at least:

- Five members with varying backgrounds (e.g., racial, gender, cultural diversity)
- One person who understands institutional commitments and regulations, applicable law
- One person who represents the perspective of research participants
- A scientist and non-scientist
- Someone not affiliated with institution
- More than one profession



Red bioethics

Research harms can still occur





Engagement as Justice

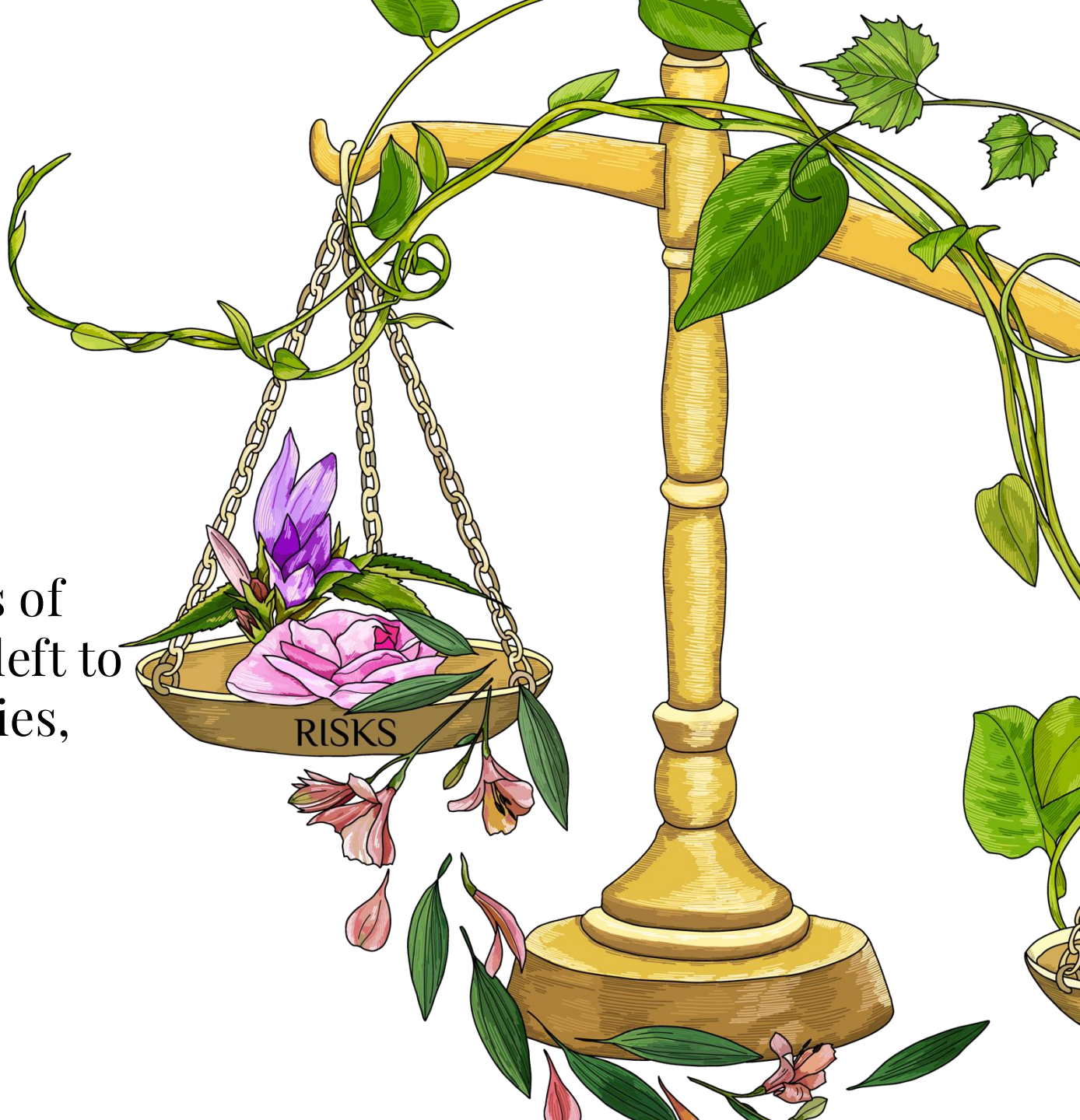
Daniels

"To meet health needs fairly, we must supplement the principles of justice…with **a fair, deliberative process**."

Arguments for doing engagement

Giving a voice?

Defining the harms and benefits of research has traditionally been left to researchers, professional societies, and regulatory bodies



Giving a voice?

Reliance on publicly available knowledge

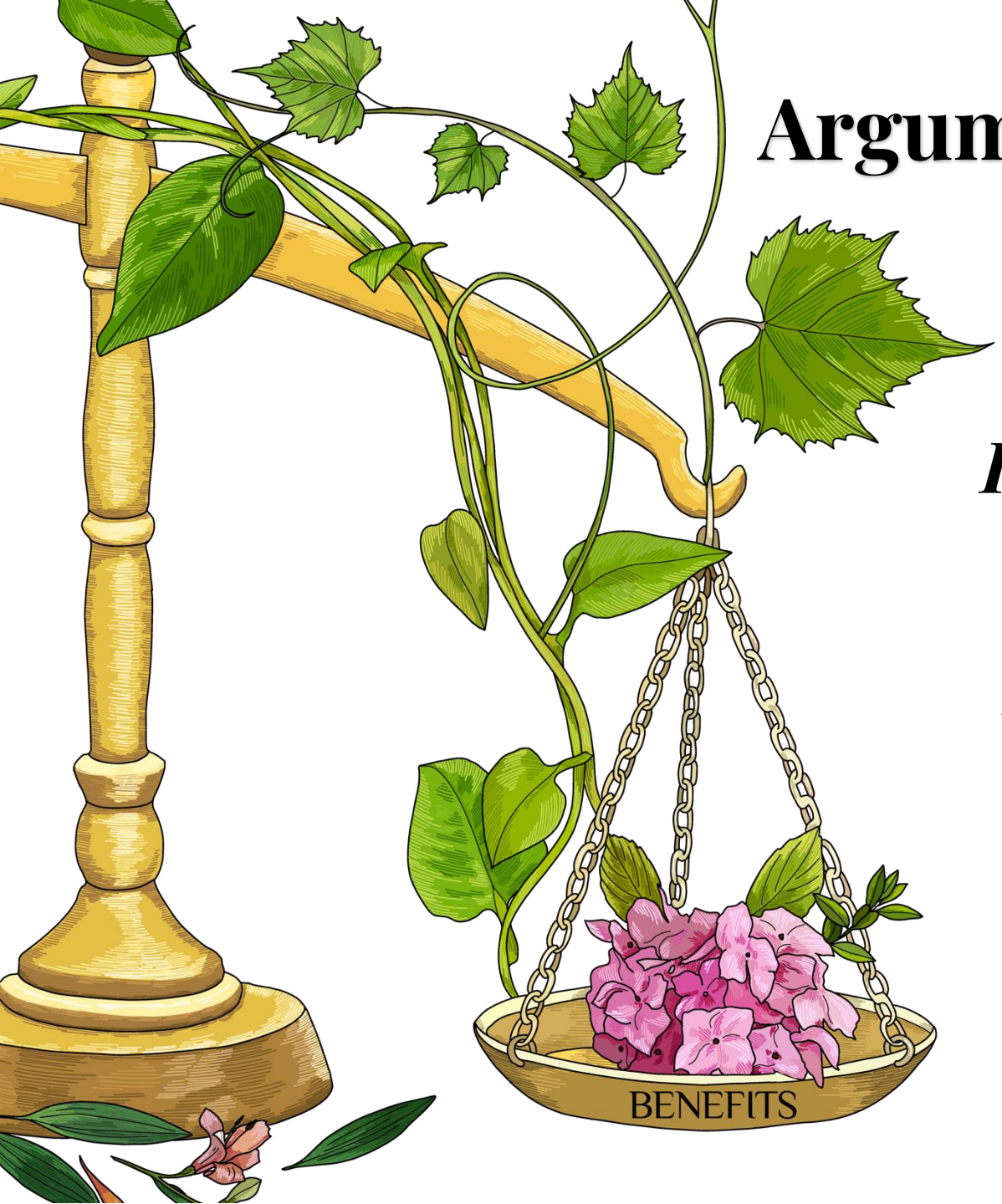
Knowledge comes with bias

- **Literature** – who's on the author list? who are they speaking on behalf of?
- **Expert opinion** – who tends to be recognized at this level?
- **Professional societies** – who belongs to these?



Who are the agents of change? (Benjamin, 2013)

Arguments for doing engagement



Identifying risks and benefits?

Existing mechanisms for regulating the ethical conduct of research are limited in their ability to anticipate and respond to the downstream implications of research, especially the potential social harms.

Arguments for doing engagement

Honoring the 'right' to engage?

"**Social justice** means ensuring that individuals, groups, and communities meaningfully participate in making decisions that have a significant impact on their well-being. Those affected **have the right** to shape a decision-making space, to be present or represented (in diversity and numbers), to raise their voice (spoken, written, or drawn), and be heard." (Pratt, 2023)



Arguments for doing engagement

A more ethical and trustworthy approach

- A key barrier to biomedical research & translation is the perception that it's untrustworthy

- A way to realize the core research ethics principles of **respect, beneficence**, and **justice**.

- A mechanism for acknowledging and addressing community and public interests, concerns, and expectations

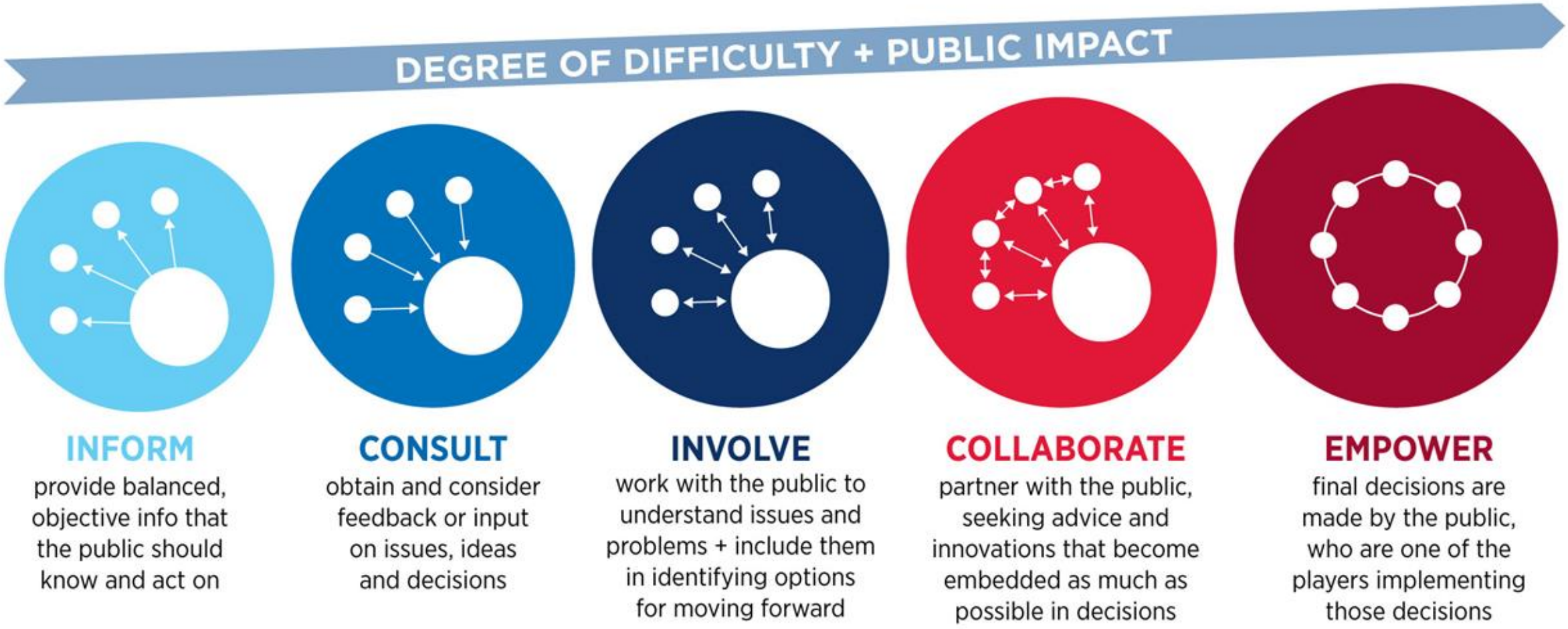


Engagement is…



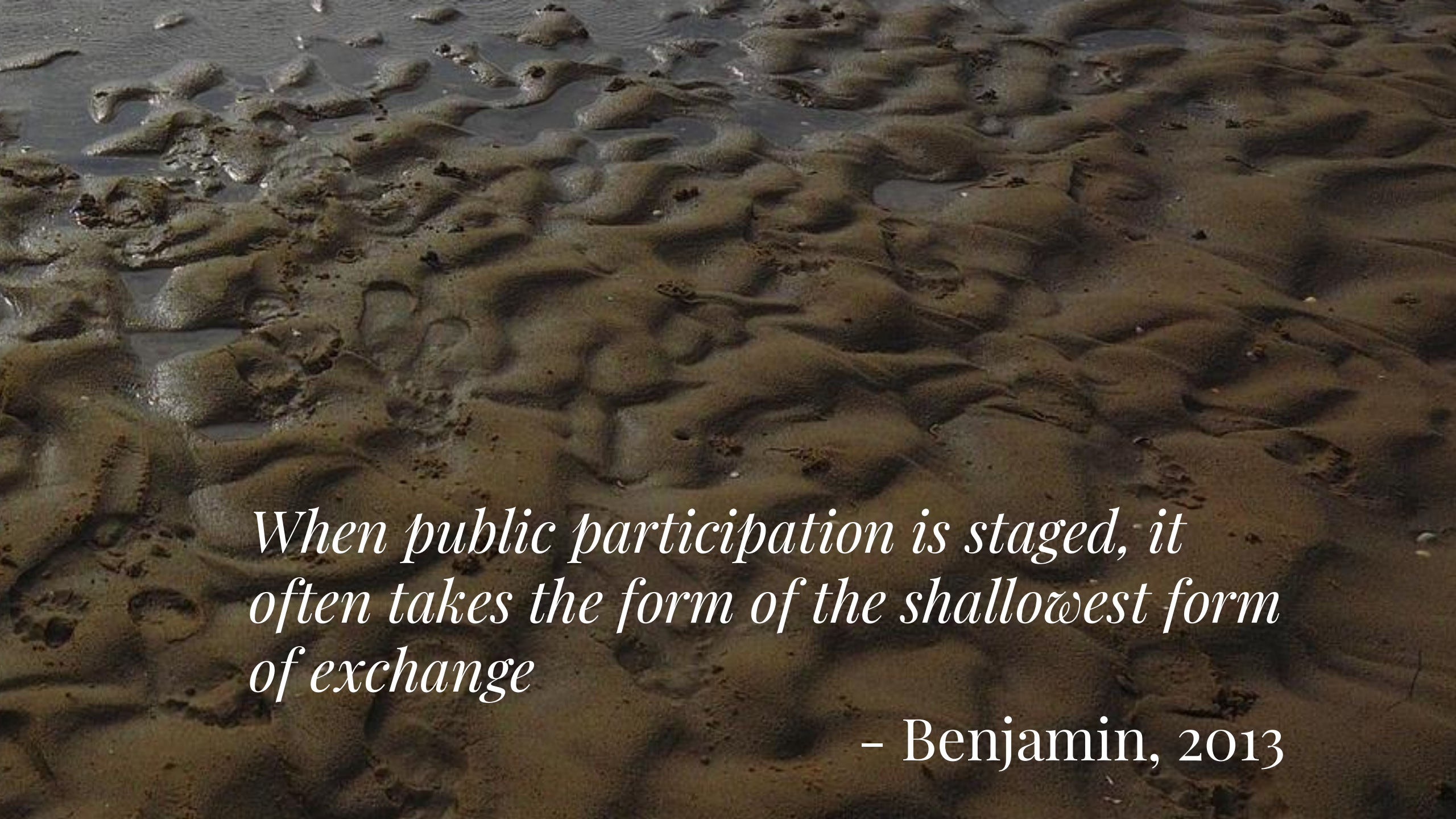
- An approach to help researchers and tech developers better identify and address **who receives the benefits and bears the burdens of research**
- A path to more informed decisions regarding study design, tech implementation
- A more robust form of citizenship, in which people actively engage in the production of knowledge (Benjamin, 2013)

To work as a form of respect, engagement must go beyond mere consultation. Requires actively listening to and incorporating the voices of those who are potentially most affected



Adapted from International Association for Public Participation (IAP2) Spectrum of Public Participation

https://research.ku.edu/community-engagement



When public participation is staged, it often takes the form of the shallowest form of exchange

– Benjamin, 2013

Partner discussion:

Thinking about the Benjamin quote, what may be problematic about shallow forms of engagement?

> *When public participation is staged, it often takes the form of the shallowest form of exchange*
>
> – Benjamin, 2013

What are problems or challenges to doing engagement?

Nobody has responded yet.

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Challenges to engagement

- **Time & resource intensive**
- **Power imbalances** between engagers and ‘the engaged’
- **Inadequate compensation** for ‘the engaged’
- "**Research fatigue**" in communities
- **Misalignment** of expectations and outcomes
- Risk of **tokenism** or "checkbox" engagement
- Dearth of empirical evidence



Sources: PCORI (2024); Shim et al. (2023); Brunger & Wall (2016)

Challenges to engagement

Problematic binaries (Hilgartner, 2021)?

- Us (Science) *vs.* them (non-scientists)
- Knowledge (Scientists) *vs.* ignorance (Lay persons)

'Engagers' can adopt a **deficit model** (McNeil, 2013; Wynne 1992)

- Assumes the 'public' lacks scientific literacy/education and that if they had it, they would 'accept' science

Science can adopt a complementary **diffusion model** (McNeil, 2013):

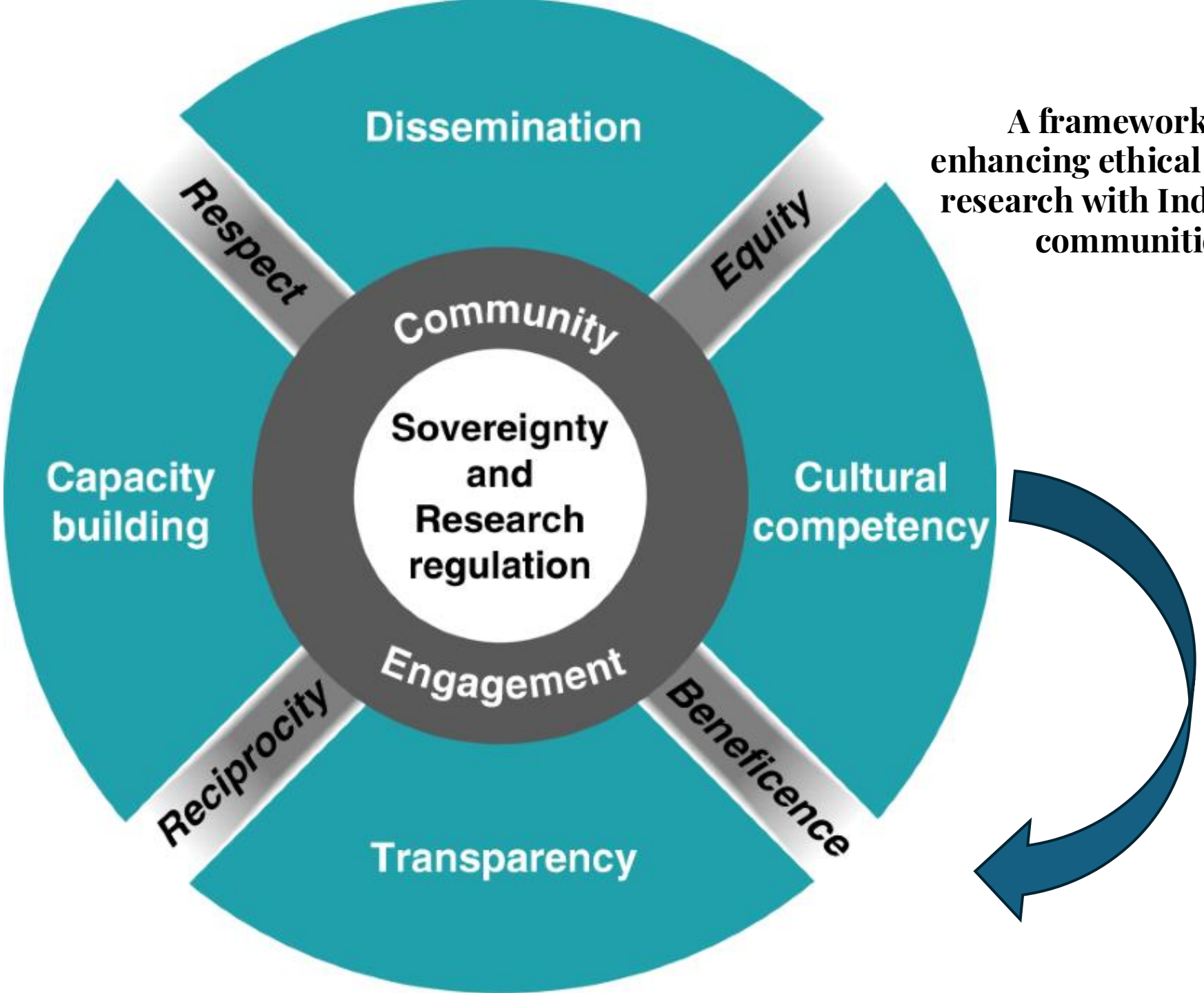
- Increased engagement by the scientific community with non-researchers can close the deficit



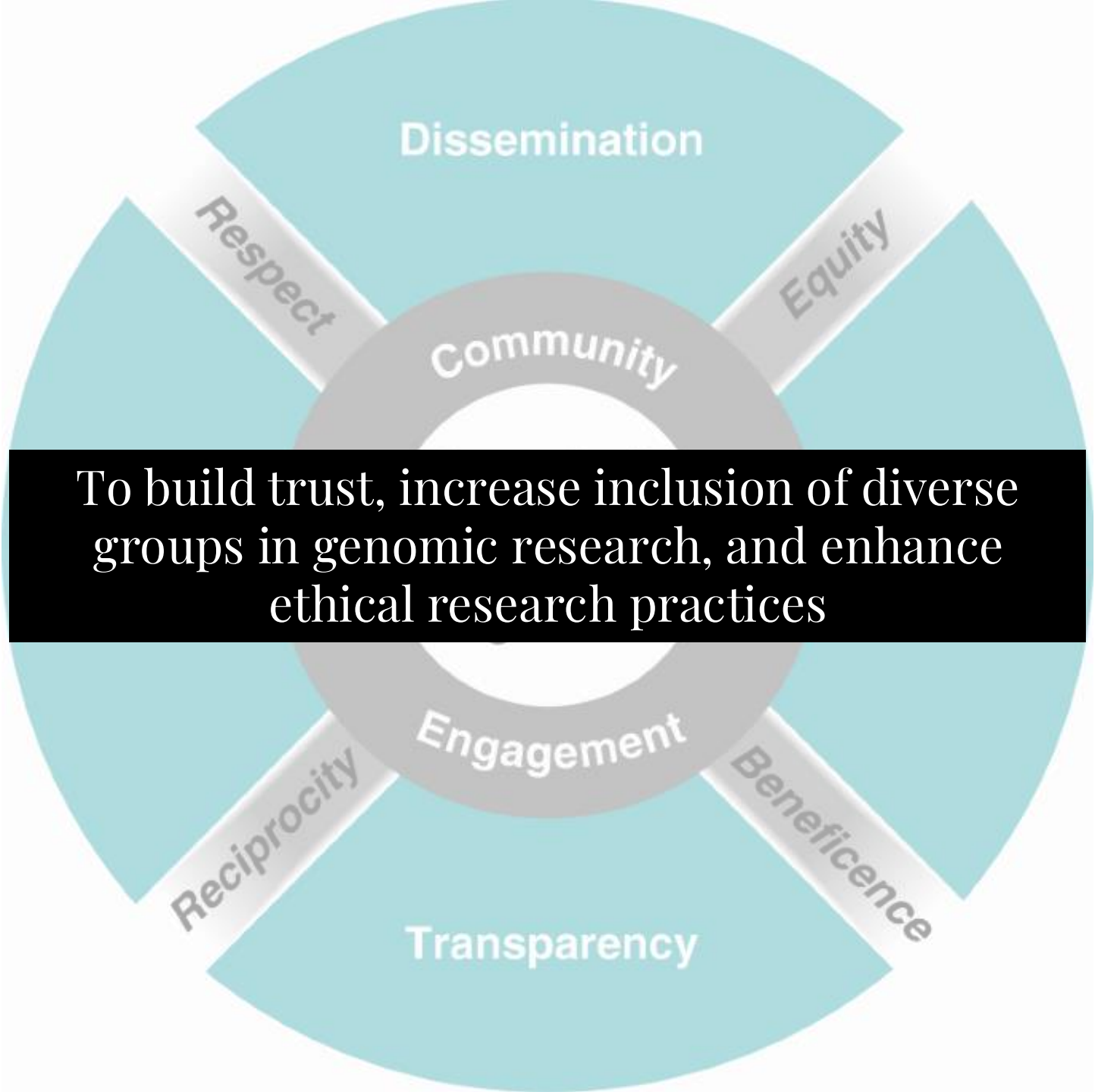
Injustice under the guise of engagement



A framework for enhancing ethical genomic research with Indigenous communities



Anderson et al, 2018



To build trust, increase inclusion of diverse groups in genomic research, and enhance ethical research practices

Anderson et al, 2018

From: A framework for enhancing ethical genomic research with Indigenous communities

Key considerations
1. Understand tribal sovereignty and research regulation Research oversight structures such as tribal IRBs, the IHS IRB, and tribal council research policies and regulations are important to consider in Indigenous communities.
2. Engage and collaborate with the tribal community Involve the community in all aspects of the research process from the initial research question development to the final dissemination of results.
3. Build cultural competency Listen and learn from the community about their cultural perspectives.
4. Improve transparency of research practices Make research goals and processes clear and understandable through frequent communication.
5. Build tribal research capacity Train and support community members in the research process.
6. Disseminate findings in a community-accessible format Collaborate with community partners to use culturally appropriate methods of disseminating and applying the findings.

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3. Build cultural competency Listen and learn from the community about their cultural perspectives.	Respect for persons, traditional knowledge, community values
4. Improve transparency of research practices Make research goals and processes clear and understandable through frequent communication.	Beneficence
5. Build tribal research capacity Train and support community members in the research process.	Tribal sovereignty, beneficence, equity
6. Disseminate findings in a community-accessible format Collaborate with community partners to use culturally appropriate methods of disseminating and applying the findings.	Beneficence, respect for persons, equity

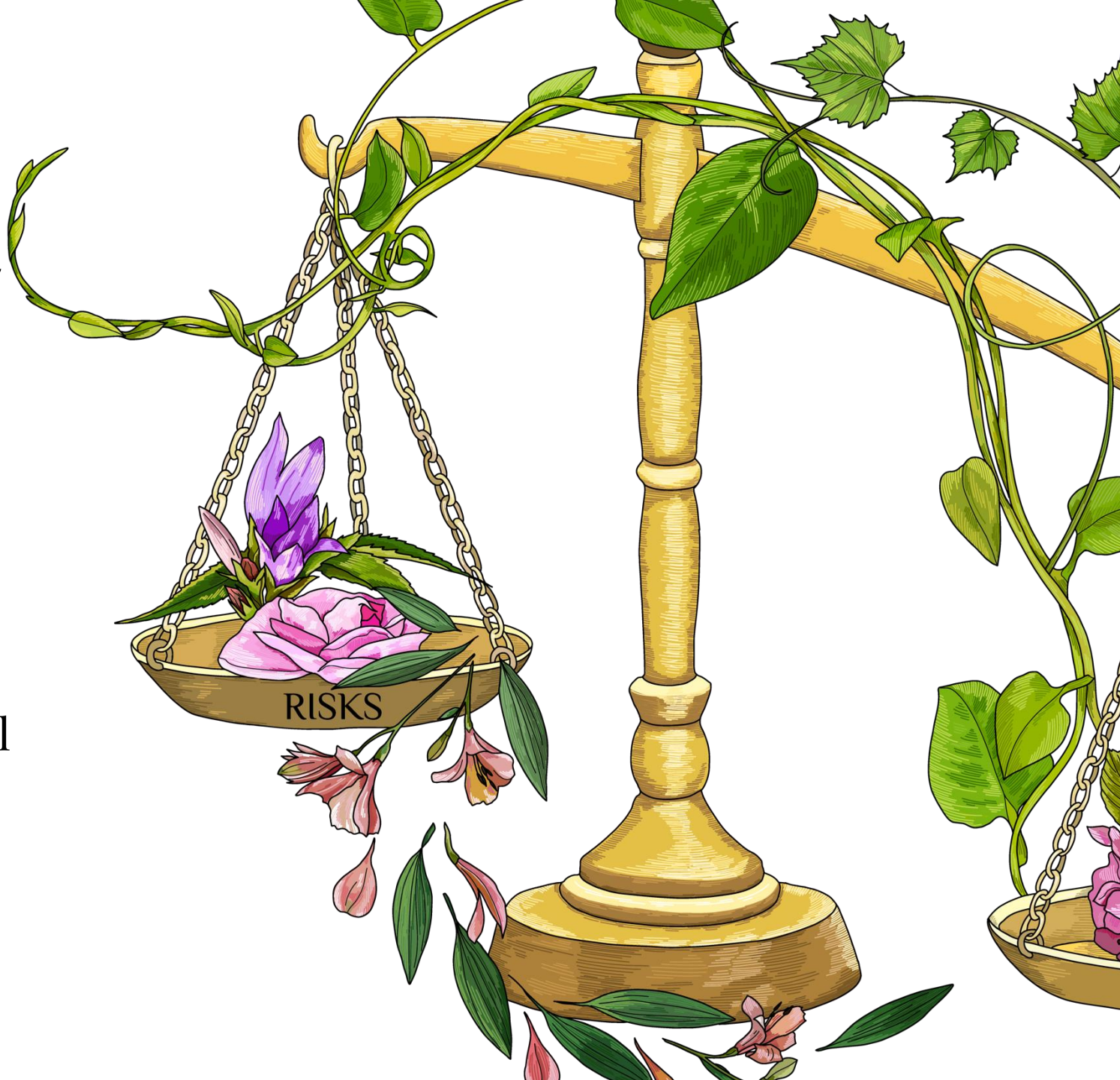
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Key considerations	Significance/s	Example/s
1. Understand tribal sovereignty and research regulation Research oversight structures such as tribal IRBs, the IHS IRB, and tribal council research policies and regulations are important to consider in Indigenous communities.	Tribal sovereignty, respect	Multiple IRB review[43], NCAI Resource Guide, CRCAIH[52], NIH Tribal Health Research Office
2. Engage and collaborate with the tribal community Involve the community in all aspects of the research process from the initial research question development to the final dissemination of results.	Reciprocity	CBPR[45], Bidirectional knowledge[48]
3. Build cultural competency Listen and learn from the community about their cultural perspectives.	Respect for persons, traditional knowledge, community values	Cultural competency training[a]
4. Improve transparency of research practices Make research goals and processes clear and understandable through frequent communication.	Beneficence	Bidirectional knowledge[48]
5. Build tribal research capacity Train and support community members in the research process.	Tribal sovereignty, beneficence, equity	CRCAIH[52], NIH Tribal Health Research Office
6. Disseminate findings in a community-accessible format Collaborate with community partners to use culturally appropriate methods of disseminating and applying the findings.	Beneficence, respect for persons, equity	Digital storytelling[63], RED Talks[b]

To summarize...

- Uncertainties and concerns about balancing benefits and risks in research and biotechnology
- Communities and patients are named as intended beneficiaries, but often left out of decision-making
- Engagement requires institutional support, bidirectional knowledge, power-sharing.
- This relationship building takes time



Looking ahead to Wednesday

Innovation and justice are sometimes seen as conflicting priorities that cannot be met simultaneously.

What do you think?